CHALLENGE 04

Your first 5 km – learn to run without overdoing it

From your first running steps to 5 km non-stop: with run-walk intervals, a clear 8-week plan and strength exercises you can do at home. Learn why patience matters so much when you start running – and why your tendons need more time than your fitness.

From walking to running

Three short sessions a week, alternating running and walking – until you can run 25 to 30 minutes at an easy pace without stopping.

8 weeks · Beginners

How each session works

3× a week

25–40 minutes

Pace: you can still chat

5 minutes · Warm-up

Walk briskly and let your arms swing loosely. Then do a few ankle circles and light high-knee steps while walking.

Main part · Alternate running and walking

Follow the weekly plan below. The walking breaks are part of it – they give tendons, bones and joints time to adapt.

5 minutes · Cool-down

Walk at an easy pace until your breathing and heart rate settle. Gentle stretching is optional if it feels good.

Afterwards · at least one rest day

Take a day off between two runs. Walking, cycling or the leg exercises below are a good fit for these days.

Slower than you think:

The most common beginner mistake is running too fast. If you can no longer speak in full sentences, slow down or walk for a bit.

Find your easy heart-rate zone with the calculator

Step by step to 5 km

Three sessions every week, each with a warm-up and cool-down. If a week feels too hard or something niggles, simply repeat it – that is not a step back, it is smart training.

Week 1 / Running: 8 min

8 × 1 min running, 90 s walking in between

Your body gets used to the new movement. Better slightly too easy than too hard.

Week 2 / Running: 12 min

6 × 2 min running, 1 min walking in between

The running intervals get longer, the walking breaks shorter.

Week 3 / Running: 15 min

5 × 3 min running, 1 min walking in between

Focus on a steady, relaxed pace rather than speed.

Week 4 / Running: 20 min

4 × 5 min running, 90 s walking in between

Your first longer stretch. If it gets hard, slow down rather than push harder.

Week 5 / Running: 24 min

3 × 8 min running, 2 min walking in between

Longer running phases – stay at a conversational pace, even if you feel strong.

Week 6 / Running: 24 min

2 × 12 min running, 2 min walking in between

Same total time as week 5, but longer continuous stretches.

Week 7 / Running: 25 min

20 min running, 2 min walking, 5 min running

Your first long block: 20 minutes without a break.

Week 8 / Goal: 5 km

25–30 min non-stop – then your first 5 km

Sessions 1 and 2: 25–30 minutes at an easy pace without stopping. Session 3: run at your own pace until you have covered 5 km. Short walking breaks are fine.

How long does 5 km take?

Many beginners need between 30 and 45 minutes for their first 5 km. The time does not matter – finishing does. If it takes you longer than eight weeks, that is completely fine.

Your fitness improves faster than your tendons

When you start running, you often notice after just a few weeks that you have more breath to spare. Your musculoskeletal system, however, needs considerably longer to get used to the new impact. This gap is exactly why many new runners increase too quickly and overload themselves.

01

Heart and circulation – weeks

Endurance improves relatively quickly with regular training. After just a few weeks, the same intervals feel easier.

02

Muscles – a few weeks

Muscles have a good blood supply and respond quickly to new stimuli. Muscle soreness in the first few days is normal and usually fades after two to three days.

03

Tendons and ligaments – months

Tendons such as the Achilles tendon have a poorer blood supply. Their tissue remodels much more slowly to become more resilient. If you increase too quickly, irritation can develop – often only hours after the run or the next morning.

04

Bones and joints – months

Bones also adapt to impact by remodelling. This takes time and recovery. Too much at once can lead to overuse problems, for example in the shins or feet.

What this means for your plan

That is why running time increases slowly in this plan, with rest days between sessions. Rules of thumb such as “no more than 10% more per week” are only rough guidance – what matters is how your body responds. Strength exercises for calves, thighs and hips help you absorb the load better.

NHS: Couch to 5K · WHO: Physical activity recommendations

Leg exercises at home

Two to three times a week, ideally on non-running days. No equipment, about 15 minutes. Perform each movement slowly and with control – quality over speed.

Calf raises

3 × 12–15 reps

Stand on a step, raise your heels and lower them slowly over three seconds. Progress to one leg. Strengthens the calf and Achilles tendon – the structures that absorb a lot of load when you run.

Squats

3 × 10–15 reps

Feet hip-width apart, weight across the whole foot, knees tracking over your toes. Lower slowly as if sitting down on a chair. Strengthens thighs and glutes.

Reverse lunges

2–3 × 8 per side

Take a big step back, lower your back knee towards the floor and push back up to standing. Builds leg strength and balance – just like the single-leg push-off when running.

Glute bridge

3 × 12–15 reps

Lie on your back with your feet flat and lift your hips until your torso and thighs form a line. Hold briefly, lower slowly. Strengthens the glutes and hamstrings, which stabilise hips and knees.

Single-leg balance

3 × 30 s per side

Stand on one leg with a slightly bent knee. To progress, close your eyes or stand on a cushion. Trains foot and ankle stability.

Forearm plank

3 × 20–40 s

Support yourself on your forearms and toes, body in a straight line, core gently engaged. A stable trunk helps you keep good form even when tired.

What matters most at the start

Comfortable running shoes

Fit and comfort matter more than brand or price. Advice from a specialist running shop can help you choose.

Muscle soreness or warning sign?

A dull, widespread ache in the muscles is normal in the first weeks. Sharp, localised or worsening pain in tendons, shins, knees or feet, however, is a signal to take a break.

Consistency over volume

Three short sessions a week achieve more than one long run at the weekend. Regular, well-dosed training is the key to adaptation.

Safety first

If you have been inactive for a long time, have a medical condition (for example of the heart or circulation) or take regular medication, get medical advice before you start. Stop immediately if you experience chest pain, unusual shortness of breath, dizziness or palpitations. Pain that gets worse while running or is still there the next morning is a reason to take a break – if it persists, have it checked. This challenge is not medical advice.

My running tracker

Tick off every session and note how it felt.

Week	Session 1	Session 2	Session 3	Notes
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				